The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Iran's president rejected Donald Trump's demand for Iran's "unconditional surrender". Masoud Pezeshkian apologised to neighbouring **Gulf states** attacked by his country since the war with America and Israel began. He later added that Iran was targeting only American military facilities in the region. However, Iranian missile and drone launches continued. The Iranian Revolutionary Guard Corps said it had launched an attack on the American base in Juffair, Bahrain.

Writing on Truth Social, **Mr Trump** claimed that Iran had "surrendered to its neighbours". He added that he was considering targeting new "areas and groups of people" for "complete destruction and certain death". Some 1,172 civilians have been killed in strikes on Iran, according to Human Rights Activists News Agency, an American group.

Mr Trump accused **Britain** of trying to join the war "after we've already won". America's president said that Britain—"once our greatest ally"—was considering sending two aircraft carriers to the Middle East. "That's OK, Prime Minister Starmer, we don't need them any longer—but we will remember," he posted. Britain

originally refused America's request to use its bases for attacks on Iran, before relenting a little.

The **United Arab Emirates** was in a "time of war", said the country's president, Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, in his first statement since the escalation of the regional conflict. More explosions were reported in Abu Dhabi, the capital, on Saturday. **Lebanon's** health ministry said that 294 people had been killed since Monday, as Israel continued to strike targets linked to Hizbullah, a militia backed by Iran.

China's president, **Xi Jinping**, escalated his warnings against "disloyalty towards the party" among the army's senior ranks, nor any "place for corruption to hide". He has already hollowed out his entire military leadership in the largest wave of purges in decades. The comments are the first direct reference to his crackdown since he sacked Zhang Youxia, China's top uniformed officer and his former friend, in January.

Balendra Shah looked set to become **Nepal's** new prime minister, as vote counting in the country's general election continued. Mr Shah was confirmed to have unseated the previous PM, Sharma KP Oli, after standing against him in his parliamentary constituency. In September a student-led revolution forced Mr Oli to stand down. Mr Shah's RSP attracted many young voters unhappy with establishment parties.

One of **OpenAI's** top researchers resigned following the firm's controversial deal with the Pentagon. Caitlin Kalinowski, who heads OpenAI's robotics team, cited her fears that, under the agreement, artificial-intelligence would be used to develop autonomous weapons and prompt "the surveillance of Americans without judicial oversight". OpenAI insists it has provisions in place to mitigate such use. Anthropic, a rival, walked away from a similar deal.

Word of the week: ***hujjat al-islam***, an Islamic title equivalent to a middle-ranking Christian priest. Read our obituary of Ali Khamenei.

Photograph: Imago

The threat of Iran’s Shahed drones

Israel and America appear to be winning the race to destroy Iran’s ballistic missiles and launchers before their Gulf allies’ missile interceptors run out. The Pentagon claims that the rate at which Iran has been firing missiles at its neighbours has already fallen by 86% since the war started. The United Arab Emirates says that whereas 137 Iranian missiles were fired at the country last Saturday, only three were on Wednesday.

Iran could be saving its best missiles for later. But for now, the biggest threat to America and its allies is Iran’s long-range Shahed “kamikaze” drones. These are cheap but accurate, and can be launched in waves from the back of trucks. Enough have been causing damage to pose a problem—one that there are as yet no good solutions to. The Pentagon is reportedly hoping to buy some of the low-cost interceptor drones that Ukraine has developed to counter the Shahed drones that Russia is fond of using.

Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump keeps one eye on the Americas

On Saturday Donald Trump will host the “Shield of the Americas” summit in Miami. The guest list is restricted to the president’s closest Latin American allies. Right-wing leaders from Argentina, Ecuador, El Salvador and Paraguay, among others, are invited. Left-wing presidents who have sparred with Mr Trump, such as Brazil’s Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, are not.

According to the White House Mr Trump’s guests have formed a “historic coalition” to fight “narco-terrorist gangs” and control migration. Daniel Noboa, Ecuador’s president, is deepening his co-operation with Mr Trump: on March 3rd the Pentagon launched joint operations with Ecuador against the country’s gangs. But other tensions could strain this coalition. The United States’ desire to diminish Chinese influence in Latin America worries countries that rely on China to buy their commodities and finance infrastructure projects. Working with Mr Trump on crime and migration is the easy part for Latin America’s MAGA men. Taking orders about China will be harder.

Photograph: AP

How animation rules the box office

“Hoppers”, Pixar’s 30th feature film, arrives in cinemas this weekend. The zany brain-swap comedy features a teenage activist, a robotic beaver and a strong ecological message. It could help to make 2026 animation’s best ever year. This summer there will be more instalments in the lucrative “Despicable Me” and “Paw Patrol” franchises, not to mention “The Super Mario Galaxy Movie”.

Such films are a huge draw. In 2024 “Inside Out 2” became the highest-grossing animated film of all time, taking $1.7bn at the global box office. In early 2025 it was eclipsed by “Ne Zha 2”, a Chinese animated fantasy which has now earned more than $2bn. (Only six other films have ever surpassed that benchmark.) It may soon be beaten by “Zootopia 2”, released in November, which has already made $1.9bn. Being part of a franchise certainly helps at the box office. Even if “Hoppers” doesn’t set the world alight, Pixar will have high hopes for this summer’s “Toy Story 5”.

Photograph: Getty Images

Harry Styles’s new direction

Harry Styles, a former member of the group One Direction who has become a blockbuster solo artist, releases “Kiss All the Time. Disco, Occasionally” this weekend. The highly anticipated album is his first since “Harry’s House” in 2022. To mark the occasion Mr Styles will perform the record in full in Manchester, near to where he grew up; the concert will also be streamed live on Netflix.

Early reviews have described the record as musically funky and experimental, but with lyrics that are a bit too meandering. (Mr Styles conceives of the album as “a long diary entry”.) His millions of fans, however, will not care. This record, like his others, is destined to dance straight to the top of the charts. Many have already bought tickets to his forthcoming tour, despite steep prices. His last concert run, in 2023, grossed $617m—one of the most lucrative tours ever. If you’re Mr Styles, things are looking groovy.

Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Mojtaba Khamenei, Iran's hidden imam

Iran's Shia faithful have long awaited the return of their hidden imam, who went into "occultation" in the ninth century. Now, some whisper, they may have one again. Rumours swirl that the Islamic Republic's 88-man Assembly of Experts has elected Mojtaba Khamenei to succeed his father, Ali Khamenei, as supreme leader. He will probably remain hiding deep underground. His father, mother, wife, sister and some other relatives were reportedly killed in Israel's opening strike of the war on February 28th. Some suspect he may have been injured too, or even killed. But his cult may survive. His followers still mourn the first Shia martyrs from 1,400 years ago as if they were part of the present.

Mojtaba, aged 56, has always been a recluse. Though he ran the *beyt*—the 4,000-man court that oversaw his father's hold on the state —almost no footage of him exists. Iranians who have met him describe him as modest and shy. He would drive to his seminary in a battered Paykan, for years the only car made in Iran, though he has been linked to investments worth millions of dollars overseas. In one photograph he peers at his father from behind a curtain.

His closest political ally is Hossein Taeb, a cleric who once ran the feared intelligence arm of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, the regime's praetorian guard. Together they hounded reformists,

backed—and it is said rigged—the election of a hardline president in 2009 and helped oversee Iran's transformation from a hybrid theocracy-cum-democracy into a security state dominated by the IRGC that crushed dissent.

For critics, Mojtaba's dynastic succession betrays the Islamic revolution that overthrew a hereditary monarchy. Even his Islam, they say, is wanting. He lacks the clerical and political qualifications that the constitution requires of a supreme leader. He has never held formal office. Nor has he published the scholarly treatise required of a *mujtahid*, a recognised religious authority—let alone attained the rank of grand ayatollah. And he lacks his father's refined oratory and intellectual air.

But for the men now running Iran, such shortcomings matter little. They are eager to project continuity. Of Khamenei's four sons, Mojtaba most resembles him. And as a veteran of the Iran-Iraq war, he shares the military mindset of the generals who dominate the regime. Before the war, some had speculated that he might become Iran's version of Muhammad bin Salman, the Saudi crown prince who sloughed off clerical control and eased verbal sparring with Israel. Israel's killing of his family extinguished such hopes. If he becomes supreme leader, paranoia and retribution will probably be his hallmarks. "He'll be an ultra-hardliner," a relative of his tells *The Economist*. Expect him to preserve his father's hostility towards Israel and America, resist internal reform and entrench the IRGC's grip on Iran's political system. And if he proves to be an absent imam? For Iran's ambitious generals, so much the better.

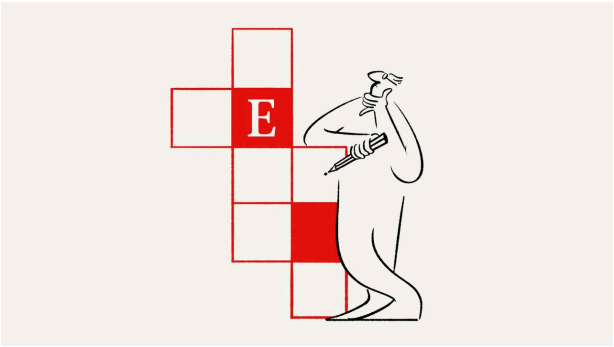

Illustration: The Economist

Weekly crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Author muzzles internal strife here (6)

2 across - Mix up tester strip (6)

3 across - Starting price of panicked retreat leads to growth (6)

1 down - Persistently attack methods to create flamboyantly betrousered singer (5,6)

Straight clues

1 across - Beleaguered strait in the Middle East (6)

2 across - Avenue or boulevard (6)

3 across - Burgeon; a largely unloved vegetable (6)

1 down - Fashionable former One Direction star who sings and acts (5,6)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Skyler Hutto, Orangeburg, South Carolina, America

Hélène Tremblay, Gatineau, Canada

Vince Sinclair, Godalming, Britain

They all gave the correct answers of: Daily Express, The Signal and the Noise, conductors, platform shoes and a track. The theme is railways (railroads) which have express trains, signals, conductors, platforms and tracks.

The questions were:

Monday: Which British newspaper, when owned by Lord Beaverbrook, had the largest circulation in the world in the 1940s?

Tuesday: Which book by Nate Silver, published in 2012, is about the art of interpreting statistics?

Wednesday: Arturo Toscanini, Leopold Stokowski and Claudio Abbado all achieved fame in what role?

Thursday: What type of footwear, which raised the user's height, was very popular in the 1970s?

Friday: What musical term refers to both an individual song on an album and an isolated channel from a single instrument that is mixed with others to make a recording?

The great nations have always acted like gangsters, and the small nations like prostitutes.

Stanley Kubrick